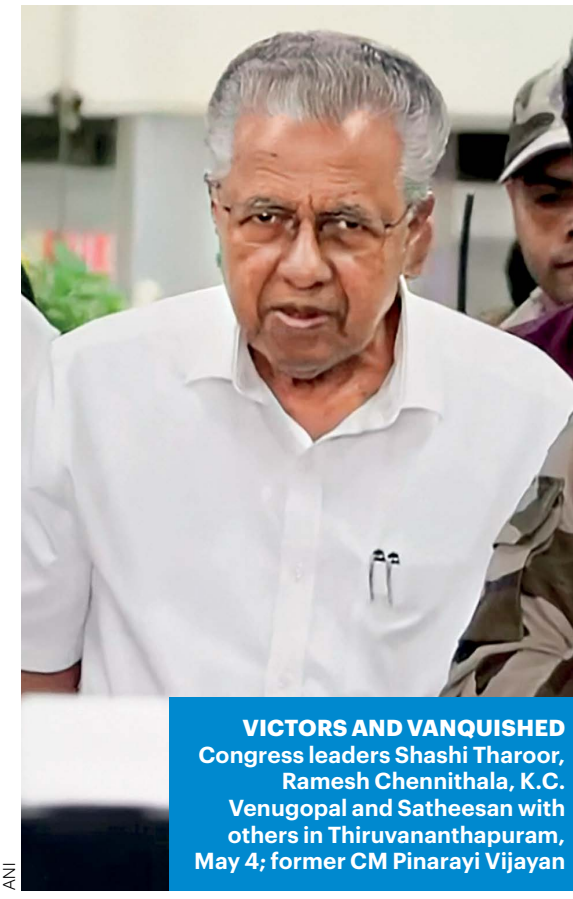




ANI

VICTORS AND VANQUISHED Congress leaders Shashi Tharoor, Ramesh Chennithala, K.C. Venugopal and Satheesan with others in Thiruvananthapuram, May 4; former CM Pinarayi Vijayan

amongst cadres eclipsed the LDF's merits—good governance, thrust on infrastructure and the completion of big-ticket projects despite fighting a cash crunch. Voters seemed to be bent on a change, ignoring the LDF's display of its developmental achievements. "The LDF government delivered the best for Kerala during the last 10 years," says Sanjeev Ramachandran, a political analyst and senior journalist. "People rated the government on certain failures that were blasted out of proportion by the media."

In a remarkable run, the UDF smashed through Wayanad, Malappuram, Ernakulam, Kottayam and Idukki districts, winning all 47 seats. "There was aversion towards the Left government among voters. The slogan 'If not the Left, who else?' reflected the leadership's arrogance, overconfidence and disregard for voters," says a retired senior bureaucrat.

The CPI(M)'s losses will also see its numbers in the Rajya Sabha go down. Of its three members in the Upper House, Dr V. Sivadasan and John Brittas retire in April 2027, while A.A. Rahim retires in April 2028.

BJP Gets a Few More

The BJP saw only a marginal increase in its vote share in 2026 (11.4 per cent) from 2021 (11.3), but it is very satisfied with its three wins—its highest so far. While state party president Rajeev Chandrasekhar wrested back the Nemom constituency from the CPI(M), former Union minister of state V. Muraleedharan and B.B. Gopakumar won from the leftist strongholds of Kazhakoottam and Chathannoor, respectively.

Though the BJP saw only a marginal increase in its vote share in 2026 (11.4 per cent) from 2021 (11.3 per cent), it is very satisfied with its three wins in Nemom, Kazhakoottam and Chathannoor

"The BJP is going to be a major political force in Kerala. We will use the platform to raise people's issues," says K. Surendran, former state BJP president who lost from Manjeshwar. Though the party leadership has its work cut out, the party did win the second place in as many as six constituencies—Attingal, Thiruvalla, Palakkad, Malampuzha, Manjeshwar and Kasaragod.

The new UDF government faces multiple administrative challenges, including an empty exchequer and the delivery of poll promises. With its manifesto promising such largesse as Rs 1,000 monthly stipend for girl students in colleges, Rs 25 lakh family health cover and Rs 3,000 monthly welfare pensions, it will have to get its fiscal management right. Drawing lessons from the LDF's rout, the new CM must also avoid centralising power and creating a personality cult, and invest all leaders with responsibility and party workers with purpose. The greatest lesson of all? The huge mandate makes it imperative for the Congress-led combine to bind itself to the grassroots. ■